

“We are open to collaborate with anybody (including LibreOffice) who is using our code base”

Interoperability is a major issue that technology makers are striving to resolve. The latest release of OpenOffice (version 4.0) also aims to do that. It is an impressive office suite that has some really cool features and offerings for open source geeks.

Diksha P Gupta from *Open Source For You* spoke to **Juergen Schmidt**, release manager, **Apache OpenOffice**, about how OpenOffice is faring against LibreOffice, the changes in the project after IBM's entry, et al. Excerpts:

Juergen Schmidt, release manager,
Apache OpenOffice

Q What features does OpenOffice 4.0 bring?

Besides many, many bug fixes, the most visible and useful new feature is the sidebar. It's not a completely new idea but a very useful change in the UI to help users to get their job done. OpenOffice has had a similar concept in Impress for some time. But Symphony adopted this idea and made it available everywhere in the office. We have now taken this idea and combined it with what was already there. For example, the writer application in the sidebar contains the navigator, the gallery, the stylist and most important, a context sensitive property panel that allows the user quick access to some of the most often used properties in the context of the current active object (simple text or graphic object, etc).

This was really a major task and we did not just migrate the

existing panels from Symphony (also contributed to Apache). We implemented a complete new framework that will allow us to provide even more useful features in the sidebar in the future. And it provides support for the developers of extensions as well. It's possible to integrate new panels in the sidebar via extensions. This, of course, can be quite useful in allowing interoperability with external third party software. I can think of an extended gallery to allow access to an online graphic repository or CMIS file storage.

But the sidebar is, of course, not the only interesting new feature in AOO 4.0.

Take a look on our release notes to get an overview on what we have done <https://cwiki.apache.org/confluence/display/OOOUSERS/AOO+4.0+Release+Notes>